

project.org

STUDENT HANDOUT

GREEN LEVEL
MORE SUPPORT

# Small Works of Power

Grades 5–8 · Art

James Tissot (1836–1902), Brooklyn Museum

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Every coin is a tiny work of art. Before anyone could read it, they could see it: a face, a symbol, a ring of letters. Two thousand years ago, rulers in Jerusalem and Rome chose those designs carefully, because a coin passed through every hand in the land.

## 01

PART 1

### Three words for reading a coin

Coin designers work with three things. Learn the words, then find them.

**Portrait** a picture of a person's face

**Symbol** an object that stands for an idea

**Inscription** words written on the coin

## 02

PART 2

### Look closely at two coins



CASE 7 · REPLICA

**The Tribute Penny**

Silver denarius, 14–37 AD. A museum-quality replica. One side carries the face of the emperor Tiberius; the other the inscription PONTIF MAXIM — *High Priest.*



CASE 7 · GENUINE

**Pontius Pilate's prutah**

Bronze, minted in 29/30 AD. One side carries a simpulum, a Roman libation ladle; the other, three bound ears of grain. No face at all.

Fill in the table. Write **yes** or **no**, then say what you see.

| DOES IT HAVE… | THE TRIBUTE PENNY | PILATE'S PRUTAH |
|---|---|---|
| A **portrait**? Whose? | | |
| A **symbol**? What? | | |
| An **inscription**? | | |

03

PART 3

## What does each coin say?

The Tribute Penny shows the emperor's face. Pilate's coin shows a ladle used in pagan worship and three ears of grain. Finish each sentence.

**The Tribute Penny says:** the emperor is...

**Pilate's coin says:** Rome is...

04

PART 4

## Design your own coin

Draw a **portrait** or a **symbol** on the front. On the back, write an **inscription** around the edge and add one small symbol in the middle.







05

PART 5

## Tell us about it

My coin shows _____ because...

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

At the exhibition, look at each coin in Cases 6 and 7. Count how many have a face and how many have only symbols.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/in-their-hands